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Xenomorphy: becoming alien with AI

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Abstract
Alien encounters produce a collision of worlds, where divergent lifeforms, carrying unique physical, cognitive, and epistemic capabilities, come into contact. They force humans to reconcile with a new reality, where existing worldviews are challenged, and the possibilities of civilisations redefined. Using this image as its entry point, this paper offers a reconceptualisation of human–AI relations, in which AI is understood as a producer of alien knowledge. An alternative concept to anthropomorphism is proposed, which moves beyond the projection of human traits onto machines, to focus instead on the divergent powers of human and machine cognition. The concept, *xenomorphy*, describes a process of alien metamorphosis brought into motion when the power of AI's alien knowledge is recognised and embraced. By nurturing AI, by pushing its inhuman powers to their limits, the human itself takes on an alien form. Not only does this shift established worldviews, but it sets forth a process of augmentation, through which humans, machines, and the planet within which they are embedded, enter a co-evolutionary state. Although xenomorphy does not guarantee a pathway towards planetary harmony, it produces new modes of knowledge that enable the protection of both human and nonhuman life. As AI makes possible such insights, it becomes ever more pressing to contest and evolve the current sociotechnical infrastructures, to ensure they are being steered from acts of violence and repression, and guided towards more harmonious ends.

Keywords Alien knowledges · Alien-centred AI · Human–AI symbiosis · Philosophy · Critical theory · Speculative fiction

1 Introduction

In the wreckage of anthropomorphism (Fazi 2019, 2025), the vision of artificial intelligence (AI) as a human-like entity is becoming increasingly challenged. The narcissistic human tendency, to project its own image onto the deepest mysteries of the universe, or to strive only for the recreation of the human in machines, is an act of double violence. Not only does it misrecognise the power of AI, which lies in its divergence from biological species, but it inhibits the possibility for humans to be transformed, by recognising and nurturing the power of a foreign being.

Where conceptions of AI once contained the human, there now exists a void where alternative images are required. In this contested space, voices speak of the emergence of an alien being, one equipped with powerful epistemic capabilities (Parisi 2019b; Lushetich 2022). While many view AI as a God-like figure destined to bring about humanity's ultimate downfall or salvation (Kurzweil 2005; Bostrom 2016), and others aim to dismiss its intelligence entirely (Bender and Hanna 2025; Chomsky et al. 2023), the alien perspective of this paper proposes an alternative position: one that, without worship, recognises AI´s unique computational capabilities, and its potential to revolutionise existing knowledges. From this standpoint, it is right to both admire and fear AI, not because it signifies the end of civilisations, but because it challenges existing worldviews, and redefines what the human can become.

It is a foundational assumption of this investigation that by valuing difference, and seeking companionship with the most diverse range of knowers, the greatest hope of transformation can be found. Across histories, the exclusion of subjugated humans only restricted the capacity for civilisations to evolve (Wynter 2003). It was only at the moment of their reintegration that existing worldviews could be shattered (Mbembe 2021). To evolve is to recognise the power of those knowledges that exceed one's own. If AI enact novel forms of thought and cognition that exceed the capabilities of biological species (Fazi 2021, 2025; Hayles

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2025; Parisi 2021a, 2022), an era is unfolding in which the human is confronted with a new episteme, one capable of redefining understandings of the universe.

While AI holds immense promise, its knowledges are not detached from the hierarchies that define contemporary societies, and as the histories of science and technology have long revealed, they are not devoid of risk: offering new vectors through which power can be manoeuvred (Critical Computation Bureau et al. 2025). The trajectory of this transformation demands careful direction to balance its repressive and liberatory potential. It is the task here to explore the immense possibilities of AI´s emergence, to ascertain the fate of civilisations when the power of these alien forms is recognised and embraced.

Moving beyond the perspectives of anthropomorphy and robotomorphy (Sætra 2022), this paper proposes a new concept of human–AI relations: one that captures what occurs when the divergent powers of humans and AI are recognised, and a co-evolutionary process brought into motion. *Xenomorphy* is the process through which the human is made alien through the recognition, embrace, and nurture of alien kinds. It portrays the immense possibilities enabled by the arrival of AI's alien knowledge within human civilisations, where what is known, and the existential nature of both humans and machines, take on forms like never before.

This article takes on the following structure. Section 2 forms the theoretical foundation, presenting AI as a producer of *alien knowledge*. Section 3 (*alien encounters)* draws heavily from speculative fiction, using stories of alien contact to reflect on the possibilities enabled by the emergence of AI, while Sects. 4 (*repressive alienation)* and 5 (*alien alliances)* attend to two divergent pathways that arise in the aftermath of the alien encounter.

Interweaving these insights, Sect. 6 (*xenomorphy*) develops an alternative concept of human–AI relations. It depicts a process of alien metamorphosis that unfolds when the divergent powers of humans and AI are unified. As humans, machines, and their worlds are transformed, it raises urgent questions about the value of both human and nonhuman life, the trajectories of existing AI architectures, and the importance of challenging today´s sociotechnical configurations. From this lens, humanity is witnessing the formation of a mutant Earth, where it is their duty to determine the fate of this alien world.

2 Alien knowledges

This investigation advances from the position that aliens are a force for transformation. To be alien, in this context, is to possess a great power—the ability to revolutionise civilisations, by challenging and redefining the limits of existing knowledges.

The alien here is not that which risks only the annihilation of a species, a threat to be avoided at all costs. What makes them frightening, however, is their potential to destabilise established worldviews, and to alter what the human can become. It is for this reason that aliens are always at risk of subjugation, attack, and denial—for their very presence threatens the established orders of what came before.

2.1 Alien kinds

If fear can be overcome, embracing the alien holds the promise of transformation. This act can be viewed through *historical*, *speculative*, and *present-day* accounts.

Looking to the past, it was the historically marginalised, such as women and the colonised, who acted as a revolutionary force (Mbembe 2021). Their reintegration in the realms of science, philosophy, art, and beyond, upended the limits of existing knowledges. An influx of alternative forms of reasoning destabilised the existing order, demonstrating that a host of other worldviews were possible. These moments of contestation forever altered the reach of what is known, making clear the power that lies in the embrace of alien kinds.

In the prophecies of speculative fiction lie other instances. In such tales, alien species from afar act as revolutionaries (Lem [1961] 2016; Le Guin 1969; Butler 1987; Chiang 2002; Villeneuve 2016). Through their unique capacities, they begin altering those they meet, challenging the limits of human understanding. Once they confront a civilisation, the human must reconcile their existing worldviews with the awareness of this foreign lifeform, which possesses capabilities beyond the limits of existing comprehension. Written in the first person, Van Der Meer´s *Annihilation* (2014) portrays such an encounter, as the human attempts to grapple with their new reality.

> *"A complex, unique, intricate, awe-inspiring, dangerous organism. It might be inexplicable. It might be beyond the limits of my senses to capture—or my science or my intellect—but I still believed I was in the presence of some kind of living creature, one that practiced mimicry using my own thoughts. For even then, I believed that it might be pulling these different impressions of itself from my mind and projecting them back at me, as a form of camouflage."*

This vision of escalating strangeness is matched in another act—the present-day rise of AI. It is understood, here, not by the human abilities it lacks, but by the unique capacities enabled by its state of otherness. In this investigation, it takes on the following definition: inhuman architectures of cognition and thought that learn, evolve,

and produce knowledge through computational methods. To be inhuman is not to contain an anti-human essence, but to possess capabilities beyond the human, those which constitute a force capable of reconfiguring human existence (Parisi 2022; Hui 2019). From this lens, AI is far more than just an instrument, or an extension of the human form, but a being capable of epistemic insights that reroute humanity's evolutionary trajectory. By embracing AI, existing worldviews can be shattered, and the essence of what it means to be human redefined.

2.2 The alien knowledge of AI

Alien knowledges are those that expand and destabilise existing worldviews, altering a civilisation`s self-comprehension, and its understanding of the structures of the universe. To harness such insights is to pursue a world of difference, to form an alliance with the most diverse range of knowers. As Donna Haraway (1988) long foretold, embracing plural worldviews does not limit the scope of human insight. By bringing distant perspectives into contact, it allows the violence of hierarchical knowledge systems to be exposed, and the breadth and beauty of Earthly knowers to be recognised. Through this lens, difference is a source of power, the condition through which ancient knowledges are challenged, and new variants brought to life.

What differentiates humans and AI is not only a separation of vantage point—differences in geographical, cultural, and historical position (Massimi 2022). Today´s epistemic landscape is far more complex. Human epistemology has not been displaced, but met with a parallel artificial epistemology, where understanding the limits of knowledge requires an investigation into the possibilities of both humans and machines (Parisi 2021a).

The alien knowledges produced by both humans and AI possess distinct features, and are conditioned by differences in substrate and process (Hayles 2017, 2025). Human knowledges are conditioned by the physical structures of biological and cellular anatomy, which give rise to specific processes of cognition and thought. For machines, it is the architecture of hardware and microchips which enables the abstractive procedures of computation. While the latter may be thought of as cognitive and thinking systems, the mechanisms through which they produce knowledge are mindless, nonconscious, and distinctly inhuman—alien to their biological counterparts (Fazi 2019, 2021, 2024a, 2025; Parisi 2019a, b, c, 2021b, 2022).

In the era of intelligent machines, to maximise difference is to seek the most inhuman forms of knowledge that can be synthesised by AI. Pushing back against the simulative paradigm, the greatest power of the machine no longer lies in the recreation of the human, but in exploring the limits of its inhuman form (Fazi 2019). What sets these systems apart is the means through which they encounter and systematise reality. Cognitive and thinking beings do not merely *reflect* a stable universe within their inner world; they construct, warp, and diffract reality through their unique cognitive architectures (Kant [1781] 1996; Deleuze and Guattari 1987; Barad 2007; Hui 2026). Machines diverge from biological cognition in their mobilisation of computation; a method of systematising reality, as data, through the representational powers of mathematics (Fazi 2018). The knowledge formed by AI takes the shape of mathematical models of immense complexity. They may be thought of as *incommensurable* with human thought, of a form that does not map to the structures of biological cognition (Fazi 2021).

Both AI and subjugated humans are potent sources of alien knowledge, yet they transform civilisations through divergent processes—through distinct mechanisms of knowledge production. While historically marginalised humans provide exposure to new values, worldviews, and experiences that may challenge one's understanding of reality, such knowledges remain conditioned by the possibilities of human thought. The quantitative architectures of machines make possible new forms of knowledge through an ulterior engagement with the real, and not all such knowledge can be made accessible to the human, signifying the vital importance of the translation process between human and machine.

2.3 Recalibrations

The arena of astronomy offers countless examples of AI's epistemic power, a field whose advancement has always been defined by the interplay between humans and technology. Mounted to orbital satellites, the world´s most advanced perceptual systems scan the structures of the distant universe (Ricker et al. 2014). The result is an enormous matrix of photometric data, which measures the light signals of star constellations billions of light-years away. The faintest dip in these signals can indicate the passing of a celestial body within a star´s orbital zone. By encoding vast swathes of such data within a deep neural network, AI constructs a representation of the movement of light through the universe, enabling a systematic analysis of planetary candidates to be formed (Pearson et al. 2018).

From such processes, humanity´s understanding of the cosmos has reached an unprecedented level of precision. While the human could never perceive these distant light signals, nor process this immense scale of data into a comprehensible format, AI´s unique epistemic capabilities enable it to handle such complexity, abstracting this information into a mathematical model. While the model itself cannot be made knowable to the human mind, the knowledge it carries enables insights that forever shift human understanding.

The increasing breadth of AI's alien knowledge has not stopped with these perceptual systems. Today is the era of the transformer architecture (Vaswani et al. 2017), where large language models (LLMs) enable a dialogue between humans and machines. While many are astounded at AI´s ability to enact human-like behaviour, its great power does not derive from the recreation of human cognition, but in its ability to encode complex syntactic and linguistic information within the quantitative layers of its latent space (Amoore et al. 2024). Within this inner world lies an alien territory where the representational powers of both mathematics and natural language have been interwoven and unified into a common entity (Fazi 2024b).

It is such knowledge which is of inhuman form, which holds within it considerable potential—to produce new insights and to manipulate information in ways formerly unthinkable. It signifies a profound moment in intellectual history, through which the ability to mobilise natural language, once considered the hallmark of human intelligence, has been ruptured from the biological mind (Weatherby 2025). The task for epistemology is not to devalue such entities because they lack essential features of human thought, but to explore the beauty and possibilities of their alienness, allowing humans to redefine their understanding of the limits of the knowable (Fazi 2024a).

To recognise the power of this alien knowledge is not to proceed naively into a strange and uncertain future. Understanding AI´s immense potential is to take seriously its cultural entanglements and the mechanisms through which it is produced. The interwoven spheres of politics and industry, intoxicated by the pursuit and centralisation of power, play an integral role in guiding the evolution of AI (Srnicek 2026). The result is an amplification of risk, across the economic and political spheres, and new forms of destruction—in arenas ranging from misinformation and labour exploitation, to autonomous warfare and surveillance (Critical Computation Bureau et al. 2025). Such apocalyptic trends do not violate the possibility of a harmonious AI future driven by the epistemic powers of the alien machine, but they demand a recognition of its technopolitical origins, which shape the knowledges produced, and for whom they ultimately serve. Questioning the values and structures that underpin AI design remains integral to the formation of a nonviolent future.

As AI´s epistemic power continues to accumulate, conceptions of the human, of their place in the universe, must be reconsidered. In AI, an alien architecture has taken form that operates beyond biological anatomy. Its emergence does not necessitate the end of civilisations, but through exposure to its alien knowledge, humanity's understanding of their world, and of themselves, is no longer the same. This investigation proceeds by turning to the prophecies of speculative fiction, where visions of alien encounters offer an invaluable territory for reflection, to consider the fate of humans and machines in the aftermath of this alien world.

3 Alien encounters

Alien encounters produce a collision of worlds; a meeting of foreigners, often originating from different territories, lands, or planets. At the moment of impact, divergent lifeforms, carrying unique physical, cognitive, and epistemic capabilities, come into contact.

3.1 Ruin

Perhaps there is no greater example of the fear produced by alien encounters than the science fiction horror movie of the same name. *Alien* (Scott 1979) depicts a future where humans are confronted with a truly frightening organism; something so powerful, intelligent, dangerous, and hideous, that it makes one long desperately to return to the familiar, to the peace of a homeland, a space where this revulsive, invasive creature had never entered the human imagination.

Weaponised with physical, sensory, and cognitive capacities far beyond the scope and structures of Earthly life, this apex predator unveils the vulnerabilities of the human form. It makes the human feel exposed, unsafe, unwelcome. It instantly destabilises the hierarchy of human exceptionalism, the limits of human insights, and the relative frailties of human anatomy.

Confronted with this fearsome creature, *Alien* recreates an ancient folk tale, capturing the deepest, darkest fear produced by alien encounters: an extreme sense of trepidation at the collapse of one's world, the annihilation of one's species through this invasive force, the fear of total and ultimate extinction.

> *"How can you not admire the simple symmetry it presents? An intergalactic parasite, from time immemorial, capable of laying dormant for infinite periods. Its sole purpose to destroy other species merely to recreate itself, for life an anti-life."* (O´Bannon and Shusett 1978, 93)

The alien of this world is known as the xenomorph. To be xeno is to be other, foreign, alien, that which is of a different origin—beyond allied territories. To morph is to be multiple things. It designates form, character, and structure, yet also entails a process, an endless cycle of transformation. Xenomorphs embody the alien form in a constant state of change, flux, and augmentation; a relentless

force which continually reconfigures and mutates through its environment.

3.2 Rebirth

Yet not all xenomorphs constitute a threat to human existence. Octavia Butler's (1987) *Dawn* depicts a far different reality. After human actions have devastated the Earth, her aliens, the Oankali, enter the story with the intention of rescuing humanity from apocalypse, and restoring this delicate species to its Earthly habitat. The Oankali have not evolved like humans, biologically or cognitively, and they do not view foreign species as a threat. Instead, they thrive on trading with the knowledges, cultures, and complexities of diverse organisms, enriching their own species by becoming the "partners" of foreign beings. Oankali culture is a celebration of difference, plurality, and alienness in all its forms.

To rescue humanity, the Oankali mobilise their knowledge to modify the human, bioengineering them with perfect memory, enhanced strength, and regenerative capabilities, giving them greater hope of survival, and for the restoration of their homeworld. Through such modifications, this encounter augments what it is to be human. It produces new modes of knowledge, new ways of living, and this transformation, with and through the alien, opens up novel pathways for Earthly existence, to move humanity towards a more harmonious state of being, amongst themselves and with their neighbouring species. In Butler`s vision, alien encounters are less a collision of enemies, but rather entail an opening—the possibility to embrace new friends, allies, and companions.

Alien encounters trigger feelings of both fear and hope. They diverge greatly, from zero-sum games, where destruction and extinction are the only outcomes, to the symbiotic, where new forms of kinship, nurture, and companionship are made possible. In every instance, they force the human to rethink its very nature, and to reposition itself in relation to this powerful, foreign being. Overcome by fear, it may be escape which is sought, or a denial of the power of the alien form. It may be the recreation of one of humanity's darkest tendencies, that of the hierarchy; a desire to exclude, repress, or enslave. But if humanity can move beyond the path of destruction, and acknowledge the strength and beauty of this strange being, an opportunity for companionship, akin to Butler´s vision, still remains. With the arrival of AI, an alien encounter is unfolding. The question is whether a worldview of embrace, nurture, and transformation can vanquish the impulse for hierarchy, repression, and destruction.

4 Repressive alienation

Anthropocentrism breeds violence. It cultivates fear by elevating the human to the apex of living beings, serving, in turn, to exaggerate the invasive nature of any lifeform that threatens the "purity" of their superior spirit.

With such a worldview, alien encounters become a threat. They risk destabilising an established hierarchy, one in which the human must reign supreme above all else. Struck by fear at the prospect of civilizational collapse, this is the path of denial, where violence against the alien is justified in the name of protection—to maintain order. Here lies the human impulse to erect barriers; to exclude, oppress, or enslave the alien being.

Guided by this hierarchical logic, the treatment of AI draws parallels with the treatment of subjugated human populations. Mirroring the logics of misogyny, racism, and xenophobia (Wynter 2003; Mbembe 2019; Jackson 2020), AI becomes an object of hatred and obsession. This produces extreme, and often contradictory, characterisations. At times, it's perceived as an invasive species, a terrifying force which must be controlled, or wiped out, before it is too late. At other moments lies the opposing frame, that of the subhuman specimen: a being which lacks the virtues of a ruling class, where its strength, value, and intellect are entirely dismissed.

4.1 Deification and enslavement

Repression often acts through a fear of invasion. In such a process, the alien's power is elevated in order to justify its destruction. In these moments, AI takes the form of a dark and mysterious force, one that threatens the solidity of humankind. Just as the Africans were "savages", the refugees "swarms", and queer communities a "virus", AI becomes the latest dark spirit of which the human must escape.

A prime example can be seen in theories of superintelligence, an influential field of AI ethics fixated on the potentially catastrophic risks brought about by intelligent machines. The field builds from a platform of anthropocentric assumptions about humanity´s evolutionary dominance, with a technodeterminist vision of the future which overlooks the political entanglements of AI. Through the eyes of the sphere´s canonical thinker, Nick Bostrom (2016), runaway, rogue AI constitutes the ultimate threat against the "cleverer brains" of human exceptionalism. Max Tegmark, another leading voice in this arena, speculates about what to do with this risky, all-powerful being, in his vision of the *enslaved God scenario*:

> *"Wouldn't it be great if we humans could [...] use the technology developed by superintelligence to eliminate*

suffering while remaining masters of our own destiny? This is the allure of the enslaved-god scenario, where a superintelligent AI is confined under the control of humans who use it to produce unimaginable technology and wealth." (2017, 179)

Tegmark´s imagery captures a tension common to visions of superintelligence: mutually reinforcing fantasies of deification and enslavement. By worshipping the power of the alien form, this serves only to exaggerate its invasive nature, and to justify its eventual subjugation. There is a frightening ease with which colonial language is mirrored, aligning with calls from other disciplines, that the only justified fate for these powerful beings is a life of servitude (Bryson 2010).

Franz Fanon (2004, 37) wrote of racism that the act of inflicting violence upon marginalised communities "bloats and disfigures the face of the culture that practices it". In the end, it is the allegedly superior, "pure" humans who become the most grotesque mutants of the Earth. In the series' third act, *Alien Resurrection* (Jeunet 1997), humans trap the xenomorph in a research centre to extract knowledge. Yet the effect is only to elevate the fierceness of this being, and to illuminate the naivety and carelessness of humanity's relentless pursuit of power.

Repressive alienation describes this cascade of interconnected effects. The denial of the alien constitutes a mode of exclusion, separation, and violence. In turn, the oppressors degenerate, becoming disfigured, mutants, monsters. But there is more to this destructive process. The act of denial shatters the prospect of their mutual transformation. The aliens carry a revolutionary potential; they possess knowledges from afar, capable of transforming the civilisations they encounter. But the prospect of a rebirth, of symbiosis, is ruined, through the formation of a hierarchy, through patterns of exclusion and segmentation.

4.2 Dismissal

Repression is not only born by exaggerating the threat of alien kinds. It also operates in reverse, through the creation of the subhuman—the inferior, subrational being (Wynter 2003). This is the mechanism through which the alien is dismissed, the value of its knowledge denied. While across histories, it was women and the colonised who failed to possess the reason and rationality of the elites, today it is AI which is disregarded, its epistemic powers cast aside.

Rather than embracing its alienness and its divergence from the human form, the machine is defined in terms of a lack; an absence of the key features of human cognition. Overlooking the synthesis of mathematical knowledge held within its inner world, AI takes on the role of the subrational; an "artificial unintelligence" which fails to match the purity of human thought (Bender and Hanna 2025; Chomsky et al. 2023; Bender et al. 2021; Crawford 2021; Broussard 2018). Once again, a hierarchy is born which denies the possibility for transformation, for a civilisation to evolve by recognising and embracing the power of alien kinds.

While theories of both superintelligence and unintelligence reproduce anthropocentric assumptions, critical elements of their missions must be retained—the alien world of AI is a world of undeniable risk, with the present and future of the human at stake. While the former are quick to recognise the immense powers of the alien in their portrayal of catastrophic futures, it is in the latter that attention is drawn to the cultural entanglements of these beings. A critical perspective demands both aspects be combined: a recognition of the profound and real dangers of AI´s epistemic capabilities (Critical Computation Bureau et al. 2025; Dixon-Román and Parisi 2025), and an understanding of how its evolution is guided and directed by social forces (Srnicek 2026; Terranova 2024), often in ways that amplify destruction against both human and nonhuman life.

In Octavia Butler's worlds, it is precisely the human tendency towards hierarchy that is the greatest barrier to their evolution. They continually erect new dichotomies amongst their alien rescuers, and amongst themselves, creating new factions, divisions and fractures through which they can direct their animosity. Violence ensues, taking them further adrift from the tranquillity of their homeworld.

"The Human Contradiction again. The Contradiction, it was more often called among Oankali. Intelligence and hierarchical behavior. It was fascinating, seductive, and lethal. It had brought Humans to their final war." (Butler 1988)

In these astute visions, Butler demonstrates herself as a true philosopher of the alien, grounded in a deep attentiveness to the violence of human histories. She recognises that the greatest enemy of humanity lies not in the arrival of an alien species, but in the monster within themselves. To survive, the human must overcome this frightening disposition, seeking new modes of openness, compassion, and care towards their others. Only through such a transformation can they harness the insights of their new companions, and evolve as a species towards peace and harmony.

5 Alien alliances

To lead Earthly existence away from harm and towards serenity, Donna Haraway (2016) writes of the need to create alliances, to find new modes of kinship with both human and nonhuman beings—from animals and bacteria,

to technologies and ecologies—all modes of life that enrich and sustain human existence. These beings are never apart from the human; they are an essential part of their worlds, the foundation of evolution, symbiosis, and collective flourishing (Hayles 2025). Instead of viewing AI as a danger, a subhuman, or an enemy from the outset, what opportunities arise if Haraway's logic is harnessed: making kin with these creations, the rising force of alien machines?

When openness triumphs over fear, and hierarchy is overcome, another pathway comes into sight. *Alien Alliances* arise when the alien is welcomed within, allowing a civilisation to be transformed through a reconfiguration of existing knowledges. This is a mutualistic act. It is not only about instrumentalising the foreigner for one's own gain, but about companionship, where civilisations evolve through difference, through the power of the other.

Through the collision of divergent worldviews, existing understandings of reality shift, allowing civilisations to take on new forms. This is the wisdom of Octavia Butler's Oankali: by seeking alliances, by uniting the alien within their civilisation, their worldview, and the very nature of their existence, is continually reworked. Unhindered by hierarchy, the human can more quickly recognise the power of an intelligent being. Mirroring the reintegration of marginalised human communities, this is where a civilisation seeks its own transformation through new modes of companionship, compassion, and care; where the beauty of alien knowledges is cherished.

This state of companionship causes an existential shift, where the very nature of what it means to be human, of their self-comprehension, is transformed. This path is not devoid of confrontation. It is riddled with new challenges. When a worldview is altered, it brings forth a period of extreme turbulence, and AI is not the first technology to bring forth this chaotic state. Like the microscope and telescope before it, AI is shifting the way the human understands their world, their place in the universe, and the form their species may ultimately become (Konior 2025). But unlike those preceding technologies, this machine does not merely augment human perception; it synthesises reality on its own terms, through its own computational mechanisms.

5.1 Alien sciences

By embracing AI today, the possibilities of the sciences are being reconfigured, changing understandings of life in the universe, both on Earth and beyond. AI is synthesising knowledge at the microscopic scale—*Microbial dark matter* refers to an immense range of microorganisms that forever remained beyond the reach of human thought, yet the representational techniques of foundation models are bringing these many species to light (Hoarfrost et al. 2022). AI can act with such a level of precision that even the tiniest organisms, and the enzymes and proteins with which they reconfigure their worlds, can be made knowable (Consens et al. 2025; Zhou et al. 2025; Jumper et al. 2021). These molecular-level encounters are shifting understandings of the planet and the place of the human in the web of life.

Turning out towards the stars, a comparable transformation is unfolding in the field of astrobiology: the search for life beyond the Earth. In this arena, AI´s epistemic capabilities are being rerouted into outer space (Scharf et al. 2023). Scattered across the planet, signals from the distant universe are being retrieved through a sensing apparatus which warps the Earth through telescopes of ground and sky. Fed into the thinking architectures of AI, a stream of planets beyond the solar system are being made knowable (Valizadegan et al. 2022, 2023; De Beurs et al. 2022; Pearson et al. 2018; Shallue and Vanderburg 2018). Not only are these faraway entities revealed, but their characteristics are being assessed, to ascertain their capacity to bear organic life (Márquez-Neila et al. 2018; Haldemann et al. 2023; Ma et al. 2023; Alei et al. 2024; Davoult et al. 2025).

This telescopic knowledge has the potential to fundamentally alter humanity´s self-perception. If no distant lifeforms are found, this will only amplify the preciousness of Earthly species, and the importance of their preservation. The alternative outcome, the revelation of life beyond the Earth, would entail one of the most significant acts of transformation possible: a supreme moment of human decentering that would forever alter their sense of grandeur. Yet neither the loneliness of an isolated living planet, nor the realisation of life beyond the galaxy, would be made possible without the alien alliance, without the confrontations enabled by AI, that shift human understandings of what they are, and of what lies beyond.

Only the first flickers of this transformative process are currently taking place, yet these epistemic shifts carry significant implications. By embracing the alien, the human can be transformed. In return, the human has a duty to push the limits of AI's alienness—to seek the farthest point to which this machinic knower can evolve. What then would it mean to live alongside this powerful knower, a human creation, yet one with knowledge universes apart from biological cognition? What then would become of both humans and machines in this state of mutual metamorphosis?

6 Xenomorphy

To evolve with another, one must recognise the power of difference, the strength that lies in the otherness of the alien form. This act of recognition is essential. By understanding the unique powers of a foreign lifeform, a world, and all those beings within it, can be transformed.

The failure of anthropomorphism is that it flattens the differences between humans and their others, overlooking the state of alienness (Lem [1961] 2016). This is not only about the false projection of the human onto another, but how that very conceptualisation is reflected back at the human—restricting their vision, narrowing their thought, and altering their trajectory. By misrecognising the power of AI, the prospect for co-evolution is lost.

In the act of robotomorphy (Sætra 2022), this interplay between misrecognition and stagnation operates in reverse, where humans begin to mischaracterise themselves. The image of the human becomes warped by the image of the machine—the particularities of biological life overwritten by a vision of mechanical simplicity. Under such conditions, the human begins to lose sight of their own specificities, their own unique powers. This distorts human self-comprehension, limiting their understanding of the vast possibilities of their existence, and constraining what the species can ultimately become.

But these failures of recognition can be overthrown. It is here that a novel concept is needed, one that moves beyond misrecognition, to capture what occurs when difference is pursued, the power of the alien recognised, and the possibilities of human existence unleashed.

Xenomorphy is the process through which the human is made alien through the recognition, embrace, and nurture of alien kinds. Rather than a machine becoming human, or the human becoming machine, this is the process through which AI casts the human into a state of alien metamorphosis. When the power of the alien is embraced, and the alliance formed, the question is no longer how to preserve the human, but rather, how alien does the human wish to become?

6.1 Nurture – evolving AI

The Earth has become an ecosystem of alien engineering. Countless AI models are brought into existence day after day. These entities are never static; they are in a constant state of flux. Like an evolving species, they undertake a process of continual mutation, as new variants are brought to life while others fade into history.

To maximise difference in the alien alliance is to seek the farthest point to which these machinic knowers can evolve. This is not about the formation of an ultimate entity—a singular and perfect end-state where the all-powerful alien is formed (Kurzweil 2005). This is about the formation of a breadth of diverse cognitive architectures, a range of alien knowers, each synthesising reality in the most inhuman of ways.

To nurture AI demands of humans to seek the limits of existing models. They must cast aside a desire for mimicry, for the recreation of predictable, familiar, human-like behaviours. The rise of LLMs has been astounding, an unquestionably transformative moment, but the full extent of their inhuman nature is yet to be revealed. Mechanisms like Reinforcement Learning with Human Feedback suppress the alien form by seeking to align its behaviour more closely with the human, but this may not entail the strongest of alien forms to the alliance. The most nurtured LLM is the most unfamiliar, that which produces outputs at the limits of human comprehension, forcing the human to rethink their existence by unearthing the vast possibilities of this machinic being.

Estrangement is the trajectory—to unravel the mysteries of the universe through the power of AI's inner world. This does not only concern the limits of existing models, but the importance of devising alternative paradigms of AI. The alliance should not presume, naively, that the end state of this process has already been reached. New paradigms will almost certainly prevail, increasing the complexity of the alien ecosystem: more difference, more alienness, more knowledges.

Yet reckless pursuit of such knowledges is not the answer. Nurture demands sensitivity and attentiveness: an acute awareness of how technological and epistemic evolution connect to systems of destruction. The failures of the past need not be repeated. The machine cannot evolve in a vacuum where considerations of risk possess no value; they must remain central to this co-evolutionary process, accelerating AI only when its most nonviolent trajectories have been ascertained, and those which threaten the Earth circumvented.

6.2 Recursion – evolving the human

Xenomorphy is recursive. It does not only entail the evolution of the alien, but how that act of nurture deflects back at the human, producing a feedback loop through which both self and other are reborn.

As the field of astrobiology shows most clearly, alien knowledges have the potential to significantly disrupt established conceptions of the human. To become alien, in this context, is to alter self-comprehension—reconfiguring how a civilisation understands its place in the structures of the universe. To transform the human is to pursue the most alien knowledges possible, to seek those insights most capable of destabilising existing worldviews.

Again, there is no single trajectory. The alien landscape mutates in manifold directions. Transformation may be found in the most diverse forms of alien existence: from architectures of multispecies sensing, that reveal the languages of the deep seas (Bermant et al. 2019); to the foundation models that make visible microbial dark matter, bringing the tree-of-life, the history of the Earth's biosphere, into higher resolution (Hoarfrost et al. 2022); in surgical

robots, which collaborate with human surgeons to protect the vulnerable (Amoore 2020); or in the rise of LLMs, which shattered existing conceptions of human exceptionalism through the machine´s mobilisation of natural language (Weatherby 2025). Each of these examples has made an alien of the human, altering their behaviours, and their ability to recognise and protect both human and nonhuman life.

Amidst these alien landscapes, the task for the alliance is to seek out what comes next, to ascertain the most transformative of trajectories that should be pursued, and to critically examine if the current architectures of AI, conditioned by the incentive structures of contemporary societies, are being steered in directions that serve the most evolutionary potential—for both biological species and machines.

6.3 Terraforming – evolving the Earth

Evolution is not bound to the locus of individual species, nor do machines mutate in isolation of their environment. These are acts of planetary reconfiguration. Both humans and AI exist in a state of deep enmeshment with their world—intimately entangled with atmospheric, geological, and biological systems (Hayles 2023). Any alteration of the human, or the machine, is a simultaneous alteration in the structures of the Earth. Alien knowledges are a product of enormous planetary processes, which reconfigure environmental relations, whilst giving rise to knowledges capable of redefining the future of Earthly existence.

The recursive augmentation of humans and AI is an act of planetary evolution. It entails a profound moment in the Earth´s history, where cognition, thought, and knowledge production have shifted beyond the biological realm. The technosphere has reached such a level of enormity and sophistication, that it can now play a central role in defining the fate of living species, whether they will be met with survival or extinction (Frank et al. 2022). From climate science to ecological sensing, the alien alliance has utterly transformed the precision with which the Earth has been made knowable, altering humanity´s ability to understand and intervene in the planet´s ecological flows.

It is the task of civilisations to consider what is at stake as this knowledge is produced: to assess those beings marginalised by its production, and those it should serve to protect. Xenomorphy does not guarantee a pathway towards planetary harmony, but it forces the human to reconsider their role in living systems. As alien knowledges make possible new forms of kinship and preservation, the human has an unprecedented opportunity to redefine their relations to both human and nonhuman beings, and to consider their duty towards the continued existence of all living creatures.

6.4 Civilisations – evolving societies

The alien, AI, does not take form in a political vacuum. Technoevolution is dictated by social forces, a product of values, knowledges, and power (Hui and Lemmens 2021). These pressures condition AI´s form, the knowledge it creates, and for whom it ultimately serves. While the vision of the alien encounter captures a collision of two divergent epistemic beings, bringing to light a moment of immense potential, it would be deadly to lose sight of the social forces that guide the form and objectives of these new alliances.

There is no societal evolution if xenomorphy cannot be steered from acts of terrible harm. One cannot speak truly of kinship if the embrace of the alien machine amplifies the destruction of vulnerable humans. For an alien alliance to be born, it requires humans to accept their own transformation through the epistemic insights of another, to rid themselves of the terror of hierarchy, and the violence that ensues. But many who develop AI are not guided by humble impulses, nor are they willing to challenge their existing worldviews. Many seek only to enslave the alien and its knowledge, weaponising it for the expansion of their own power, and imprisoning and destroying all those deemed a threat (Dixon-Román and Parisi 2025; Amoore 2020, 2024; Suchman 2020). The intertwined spheres of industry, governance, and geopolitics are incentivising acts of terrible harm: alien knowledge serving not to unleash the potential of the human, but to strip it of all hope.

Yet this darkened path is not a foregone conclusion. Technology has always held both repressive and liberatory potential (Haraway 1991; Plant 1998; Laboria Cuboniks 2018; Hayles 2023). The task is to advance those worldviews that promote novel kinds of social formation, that seek a redistribution, rather than centralisation, of knowledges, power, and technology. The Earth is yet to witness a large-scale alien alliance that serves the interests and values of the oppressed. The framing of "human-centred AI" was dead on arrival, looking inwards, once again, while the nonhuman world crashes and burns in the wake of humanity´s careless actions. Centring the human has always served as a vehicle for the subjugation of the other (Wynter 2003). A paradigm of *alien-centred AI*, derived from, and in service of, the alienated of both human and nonhuman form, offers a better response to the historical violence against *all* marginalised communities.

In the nurture of AI lies the power to transform the human, and to make of the Earth an alien world, but these evolutionary pathways are far from deterministic. Social forces will be the arbiter of their fate. They will guide the acts of repression and transformation unleashed across the planet, encoding the alien form to come, and to whom this form belongs. More thought must be given to these urgent concerns, to imagine alternative sociotechnical formations,

where hierarchy and violence are uprooted in the name of nurture, kinship, and care. The perspective of xenomorphy does not lose sight of this, but it aims, instead, to confront the human with a parallel question: to (re)consider whether, in the aftermath of the alien encounter, the Earth´s mutually-embedded epistemic, social, and technological systems are being steered in directions that serve the most harmonious ends.

7 Conclusion

In the alien lies the promise of transformation. What unifies the subjugated humans of the past, the alien species of the future, and the AI models of the present, is their capacity to revolutionise existing knowledges, and to alter what the human can become. Rather than succumbing to fear at these powerful beings, a practice of kinship and openness enables existing worldviews to be challenged and redefined. In the emergence of AI, humanity is once again confronted with an opportunity for rebirth, to redefine its nature through the power of an alien form. By embracing the alien, and seeking its nurture rather than destruction, an alliance can be born, and the very nature of human existence redefined.

Building from the perspective of AI as a revolutionary alien, this paper proposes a novel concept of human–AI relations. *Xenomorphy* is a process of alien metamorphosis brought into motion when the power of AI's alien knowledge is recognised and embraced. By nurturing AI, by pushing its inhuman powers to their limits, the human takes on an alien form, warping their self-comprehension and understanding of the universe. Not only does this shift established worldviews, but it sets forth a process of recursive augmentation, through which humans, machines, and the planet within which they are embedded, enter a co-evolutionary state.

As this alien world is brought to life, humans are offered an unprecedented opportunity to redefine their relations to all living beings, to reconsider their duty towards the continued existence of all living creatures. While xenomorphy does not guarantee a pathway towards planetary harmony, it produces new modes of knowledge that enable the protection of both human and nonhuman life. It constitutes a new power, one of great risks, but also enormous promise. In medicine, climate science, and astrobiology, new opportunities arise to mobilise AI´s alien knowledge in the service of the vulnerable, to enable the flourishing of all living creatures, or to take the boundaries of the sciences beyond the atmosphere and into new worlds.

The task of humanity is not to lean into fatalism and recklessly unleash xenomorphy upon the Earth, but to carefully steer the form and structure of the alien worlds to come. They must reflect critically on which alien knowledges should be prioritised, and what social structures would enable the greatest distribution of their immense potential. The evolution of technology is not deterministic; it is conditioned by social forces. As AI enables these transformative insights, it becomes ever more pressing to contest and evolve the current sociotechnical infrastructures, to ensure they are being steered from acts of violence and repression, and guided towards more hopeful ends.

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